

Use of Digital Technology in Publishing Works of Scripture

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

5 September 2016

To a Bahá'í Publishing Trust

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

Your email letter dated 16 April 2016 outlining your plans for a new approach to publishing Bahá'í literature in ... and your email letter of 22 February 2016 requesting digital files of various publications have been received by the Universal House of Justice, and we have been asked to reply as follows.

The detailed presentation of your thoughts on the application of digital technology to Bahá'í publishing was appreciated. It is understood that you envision [your] role as shifting from a focus on traditional book publishing to the digital management of texts and translations. Undoubtedly, advances in technology have made possible the dissemination of Bahá'í literature to a degree hitherto unimaginable, and that potential must certainly be harnessed and deployed to the fullest. Yet, for all its formidable power and potential, technology is a tool that serves other higher goals and purposes and should not become the chief determinant of direction. The possibilities it offers must be evaluated with attention to their impact on the encounter between the reader and the revealed Word. Consider, for example, the capability of hypertext to make supplemental information from a multitude of sources immediately accessible to the reader. While that is unquestionably valuable in some contexts, there are principles to consider. Throughout history the practice of combining commentary and Sacred Text has been ubiquitous; only in this Dispensation has it become possible for each individual to read the Word of God and its authorized interpretations without the mediation of a priestly class. Because of the need to avoid encumbering the Text with commentary, the House of Justice has determined that it would be inappropriate to publish editions of the Writings that incorporate study guides or other extensive explanatory material. When viewed in light of such considerations, the provision of substantial supplemental information in conjunction with the Text would not be appropriate. It should be noted that there is a distinction between what an individual may freely do for his or her own use and what is appropriate for a Bahá'í agency to issue as an edition of the Holy Text.

To offer another example, the practice of repeatedly revising translations must be viewed in light of the impact of frequent change upon readers—a consideration that outweighs all but the most serious of corrections or revisions to the translation of a text. As the House of Justice has indicated in a letter dated 7 October 1973 to a National Assembly:

You will find that where translations already exist believers will have formed many emotional attachments to the forms of words used. In the case of prayers for example, they may have committed many of them to memory. It is thus unwise to repeatedly change translations and therefore we advise you to do so only when the translations are really poor and there are obvious errors, and to concentrate your efforts on obtaining translations of the great volume of Bahá'í literature which has not yet been made available....

It should be remembered that however advanced digital technology seems to be today, it is still new and at an early stage of its development. As its capabilities become more refined in the future, some of the

problems you noted, such as the difficulty in recognizing variant spellings and transliterations of the same word or phrase, may be resolved. In that event, to resort to the drastic step of changing the texts to accommodate the limitations of today's technology would be premature. In any case, the thousands of texts that comprise the unprecedented, incomparably rich treasury of writings of the Central Figures of the Faith and the beloved Guardian must be approached on their own terms, in all their complexity and variety, rather than as objects to be standardized so they may be managed by a system. It is helpful to keep in mind that although standardization is reasonable at the level of an individual text, a library is not a text but a collection of many different books, each with its own individuality.

With respect to the English-language works available at this time on the new Bahá'í Reference Library website, those that are the most recent publications of the Bahá'í World Centre represent the current versions of those books, while others reproduce printed editions from the United States Bahá'í Publishing Trust. Publishers and translators are still advised to refer to the most recent printing of works and to contact the World Centre for information about editorial corrections that have been approved but not yet incorporated into a published edition.

The vision for the Bahá'í Reference Library approved by the House of Justice includes some of the goals you have outlined, such as the assignment of reference numbers, which will be implemented as time and resources permit. Paragraph numbers are already included in the downloads for a number of works in the Reference Library. However, in the planning and implementation of the Library various approaches and issues, including some mentioned in your letter, were considered and evaluated in light of relevant factors as well as the learning gained, and decisions as a result were made to develop the Library in a particular direction. As you rightly note, international coordination is necessary if any system is to function properly, but such coordination naturally must come from the World Centre. It would be counterproductive for national agencies to launch their own systems intended for universal use or to outpace developments at the World Centre. Therefore, before proceeding further, it would no doubt be helpful for you to consult with your National Assembly about the direction and focus of the [Publishing Trust] and how it can best serve the needs of the Cause.

Be assured of the prayers of the House of Justice at the Sacred Threshold that your endeavours in the path of service may attract divine confirmations.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]